

PICTURE ON THE WALL

Volume 1. Issue 5. March 2023

A conversation took place standing in the entrance to 32 Signal's Regiment Officer's Mess in Fort York, Toronto.



"We are running out of space. Let's take down these old CO pictures and make room for more recent portraits." Past Commanding Officers from 2 Sigs; 8 Sigs; 709 Comms stared back at us. Some of the portraits showed some COs' wearing the military M.B.E medal. (*M.B.E Member of the Most Excellent Order of the British Empire. Created by King George V*) We needed to find out more about these members This is the story of one picture on the wall.

David Watson, Commanding Officer 8th Sig Regt 1953-1956

When Dave Watson was asked about his service and how he got to Sicily in 1944, he replied "I swam. The pilot dropped us short."

Colonel David B. Watson became Commanding Officer of 8th Signal Regiment. In 1963 he was appointed Honorary Lieutenant Colonel and later in 1968 the Honorary Colonel, retiring in 1973. His wife, Nancy served as an officer in the Regiment and still attends Regimental events.

David joined the British Territorial Army in 1938 and with the outbreak of WWII was commissioned in 1940 into the Royal Corps of Signals joining the 1st (British) Airborne Division.



In February 1942, Britain was at a low ebb in the War. HMS Prince of Wales had been sunk and worse, the German Battle cruisers Scharnhorst and Gneisenau with Prinz Eugen had sailed up the English Channel unnoticed despite British radar. The analysis of this failure was that the German radar had successfully neutralised the British systems. The German radar officer who achieved this was General Wolfgang Mazzini who arranged for the level of jamming to be increased slowly day by day until the jamming was

complete and unnoticed. A flight by a photographic Spitfire pilot, Tony Hill located a German Wurzburg radar on an isolated clifftop in France. Here was an example of the German technology. R.V Jones of British Scientific Intelligence created the idea that became the Bruneval Raid. This was a Signal

Intelligence raid to capture parts of the radar and destroy the site. Captain David Watson as a Signals member of 1st Airborne Division was part of 'Operation Biting' that brought back the technology of the Wurtzburg, so critical to the future of the D-Day invasion.

In November 1942, David parachuted into Bone, Algeria as part of 1st Parachute Brigade at the beginning of Operation Torch, the invasion of North Africa.

During David's next jump, he was part of the Sicily Campaign. The pilot of his aircraft dropped him short of the landing zone and into the sea, losing all his equipment. As David put it, he was useless without his gear so the Navy picked him up and he ended up back in North Africa via Malta. In September 1943 David eventually arrived in Taranto by sea and began his Italian campaign



In January 1944 David returned to the United Kingdom and back to the 1st Airborne Division Signals where on promotion to Major he took command of the Signals Company.

D-Day and Normandy saw David attached to 101st (US) Airborne Division ready for D-Day and the Normandy campaign. He was to provide the rear and lateral communications links for the 6th (British), 82nd (US) and

101st (US) Airborne Divisions in France. He jumped into Normandy with the 101st (US) Airborne. Their mission was to aide the 4th (US) Infantry Division to come ashore on Utah Beach by causing discord and confusion to the German defenders. 6,600 paratroopers from the 101st were successful in their landing but 1,500 missed the drop zone and were captured or killed by the enemy.



By September 1944, the Allies had broken out of Normandy and pushing across Holland and France. A gamble was taken to make an airborne assault by 3 Airborne Divisions to secure key bridges along the expected Allies axis of advance. David as member of 1st Airborne Division Signals was part of Operation Market Garden and parachuted into Arnhem in Holland.

The No 22 radio used in Arnhem only had a range of 6 miles was unsuitable for the task and communications relied on No 19 sets, Line and the civilian telephone networks. The 82 pigeons were not successful as they were reluctant to leave the locale, only 14 made it back to their lofts. A German pigeon loft within the Airborne defences attracted a number of

German messenger pigeons whose messages were passed to the Intelligence section. The Airborne were experiencing difficulties with communications since the day time crystals were not working and they were using night frequency crystals and even using the BBC Radio network with a 76 set to get messages through. The Germans were in very close proximity. The Arnhem telephone exchange was within the Airborne defences and controlled the Arnhem area telephone system. David received a message that a German Officer wanted to speak to the senior signals officer. David rudely declined several times. The Officer spoke perfect English and

eventually David spoke to him. The German suggested that they were both blocking each others phones and no one could send any messages, that they could take turns on the quarter hour an the half hour. It made sense, so David agreed and this arrangement continued until the Germans were out of range. David said that this was the only time he collaborated with the enemy. David and his unit were withdrawn to HQ Airborne Corps at Nijmegen and were back to the UK a month later.

By April 1945 David was part of the planning team for an Airborne attack on Rangoon and Singapore. He was part of the unit advance party that left by sea for India. By September 1945 Japan had surrendered and David had been discharged after 6 and a half years at war, David Watson was awarded an M.B.E The Territorial Efficiency Medal; twice mentioned in Despatches and 4 campaign stars.

David came across to Canada and in 1947 was appointed as a Captain in 1st Corps Signals Regiment, Royal Canadian Corps of Signals (Militia). Then appointed as Commanding Officer and Lieutenant Colonel of 8th Signal Regiment. In 1963 David was awarded the Coronation Medal. Prior to retirement in 1961 he was appointed the senior Staff Officer of 14 Militia Group.

In 1963 Colonel Watson was appointed Honorary Lieutenant Colonel of the Toronto Signal Regiment and Honorary Colonel in 1968. He finally retired in 1973.

David Barr Watson M.B.E., TEM. CD. B.Com died on Wednesday 9th April 2003 at the age of 83. His obituary noted he was born in Swansea, Wales and educated in the London School of Economics. Also, in World War II he was Commanding Officer of 1st British Airborne Division Signals was awarded the MBE and twice mentioned in Despatches for gallantry. After coming to Canada, he joined 8 Signal Regiment and was appointed Honorary Colonel 709 (Toronto) Communication Regiment. He established a worldwide reputation as a Management Information Systems specialist and developed many unique computer systems and retired in 1981,

‘PICTURE ON THE WALL’ is the story of our Regiment told through the images you may see on the walls of our Unit Lines. If you would like to know more, please ask any senior member or email HCol Ken Lloyd kenlloyd.mediator@gmail.com.